

Womenomics: Gender Inclusivity as a Grow Strategy in Japan

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ABSTRACT

As a developed country, Japan is not immune to difficulties. Hyper-aged population, economic stagnation, and gender inequality are some of the crucial issues. The presence of the Womenomics policy in 2013 as an effort to empower women in Japan is one of the Japanese government's solutions to mitigate the problem of hyper-aged population, economic stagnation, and gender disparity. This research aims to discover and examine the challenges of the 21st century in Japan, particularly the subject of women's empowerment and its correlation with economic growth. The descriptive qualitative case study research method was applied to examine the political goods within the Womenomics policy. With a public policy approach, the study's findings represent Japan's efforts to implement an gender-based innovative policy that allows Japanese women to access equal opportunities in social, political, education, and economic sectors to increase the labour force number as the growth strategy to mitigate the impact of the hyper-aged population in Japan. This policy shows that Japanese women have grown in the workplace, however many challenges still occur to tackle the gender-biased paradigm in Japanese society, such as wage-gap problems.

Keywords: Japan; Gender Inclusivity; Innovative Policy; Womenomics

INTRODUCTION

The patriarchal ideology has been around for a long time, limiting how women act in public. This ideology is the core problem of the gender inequality problem in Japanese society that has long been a global issue. Japan is one of the most developed countries in Asia regarding technology and many other aspects. However, if we trace the track back to the 20th century, we can see how women in Japan have limited access to act in public. In the Confucian view, women must obey three men: their father, husband, and sons. Women are seen as incompetent. Therefore there is a big superiority complex in the country that limits women.

The superiority complex hanging around in Japan revolves around every aspect, certainty that the speech forms used between the masculine and feminine, the seating arrangement, and the style of interaction will all demonstrate the superiority of the male and subordinate status of the female. The Japanese hiring system was very male-dominant, and even though there were many opportunities, even more than in the US, the women in Japan did not feel that because they never got the options.

Talking about the issue of women's liberation from the confines of patriarchal thought does experience complex dynamics. Women in Japan got their right to vote for the first time on April 10, 1946. Based on the writings of Taki Fujita, namely Women and Politics in Japan, Japanese women have been fighting for their right to vote for more than 30 years. Previously, women's political rights successfully obtained were limited to attending political gatherings after the New Women's Association struggle chaired by Raicho Hiratsuka when previously banned before 1919. By amendment, The General Election Law finally allowed women to participate in elections in general. As evidenced by the election of women in local

assemblies even though they are in large numbers, namely only 1.6 percent in prefectural assemblies, 1.1 percent in city assemblies, and 0.6 percent in the village and village assemblies (Fujita, 1968). Progress of political rights for women in Japan could be faster. The highest number of political participation women in the national diet was 73 women in the 2000s (Usui, et al., 2003). In 2014, only 169 female candidates took part in the general election, out of 1093 or 15%.

Even after the right to vote for Japanese women, their hardship did not stop there. Women are still marginalised from the decision-making activities of leftist groups driving activists, as well as at work. Women's reproductive function is considered an obstacle that makes women considered to have functional limitations. The current problems in the 21st century regarding women in Japan are Gender Discrimination at the University of Tokyo Medical School and Gender-Based Discrimination in Japan's Olympic and Paralympic Administration. The University of Tokyo was proven to manipulate the test scores of men and women. They controlled the men's scores just so more men could get into medical school because many women doctors left their job to give birth to children or get married. Another current problem regarding this issue in Japan is the Tokyo Olympic organising committee president, who throws a sexist comment in one of his speeches regarding how women talk too much. This sexist comment has spotlighted how far Japan lags behind other prosperous countries in advancing women in politics or the boardrooms. Japan stands 121st out of 153 in the World Economic Forum's gender equality rankings. These two news stories are only examples of how the patriarchal form of culture is still attached to Japanese government bodies, especially conservative groups, and legitimise that women are physically incapable and their capacity to become a doctor or athletes.

We cannot deny that economic development has become a force to be reckoned with, and many wonder how long Japan can continue to prosper. Looking back at Japan's current economic development, the quantity of growth has yet to show any evidence of significant improvement in the last decade or so, causing the country to confront economic stagnation. The stagnating economy is tied to their country's labour productivity, which is now facing a hyper-aged population condition; the country is getting more older people rather than infants. Ironically, this situation is getting worse because of the gender gap which directly narrows Japanese women's participation in the labour force for decades. Thus, it became critical for Japan to increase its population and labour force number in order to help the economy.

Therefore, reflecting on the economic urgency, all these limitations for women then resulted in gender wage differences and the glass ceiling phenomenon. This inequality also occurs in the economic and employment fields. There is still a significant wage gap between women and men. Namely, Japan is one of the countries with the most considerable wage gap among all OECD (Economic Co-operation and Development) countries. Reporting to the OECD's official website, in 2021, Japan ranks third in the gender wage gap, which is 22.1%. By 2022, it is estimated that the gender pay gap in Japan will be 22%. The factors behind this are the regular and non-regular employment system— many women become non-regular workers who are low-paid, have deadlines, and have specific work obligations (Yamaguchi, 2019), and the low percentage of women occupying managerial positions. The human resource management system also influences this wage gap with gender differences (Hara, 2016). This model contributes significantly to the creation of implicit gender boundaries in society.

From this wage gap problem, the glass ceiling phenomenon is a current problem for Japanese women pursuing their careers. The glass ceiling phenomenon is where it is difficult for women to advance their career positions to a higher level in an institution. This

phenomenon happened because of the constant act of belittling women. All those limiting women's acts result in gender stereotypes that women are best at home, caring for their children and family rather than working and pursuing their careers. People constantly see women incapable of building connections with others and actualizing themselves at work. Besides those biased genders, women's double burden of constantly choosing between their families or jobs also pushed them back.

Of all the problems presented and to achieve an inclusive, equal, and just society, it is essential to create a healthy space for all sections of society without exception. Departing from discrimination and the absence of fulfilling women's rights in Japan in the private and public spheres, it cannot be denied that Japanese women still often experience objectification, violence, and injustice, which place women amid powerlessness. The role of women is often belittled and sidelined. Not to mention compartmentalised based on class stratification and segregated in society. It is then crucial to ensure that the role and potential of women can be pushed to the maximum level, giving them a healthy and fair space to bestow their contributions in all sectors. Ensuring equal access and opportunity is one of the efforts that can be made to implement women's empowerment and encourage maximising the role and potential of women in the private and public spheres.

Therefore, empowering women is an important thing to do in order to achieve a Japanese society that is inclusive, equal, and just in all aspects of life. This is also a crucial effort to lift Japan's economic stagnation and mitigate the hyper-aged population impact that has haunted Japan for the past few decades. Amid this alarming situation, a "Womenomics" policy emerged, encouraging equal access for women in education and the workforce. Even though a gender-based policy is essential to boost traditional stigma and create more inclusive social penetration, it is still important to analyze the political goods of the policy. It is necessary to analyze the values and factors that drive the transformation of a conservative political system which turn into a gender inclusive one (system goods), input and output from political processes that involve the society and government to issue a gender-based policy (process goods), and public expectations of the government and its policies (policy goods).

ANALYTICAL FRAMEWORK

To support this research, researchers collect relevant previous research. The first article we used was research titled "Injustice Continuity: Gender Inequality in Japan in the Twenty-First Century" by Arifin, M (2021). This study discusses Japan as a highly developed country in terms of its economy. The combination of Japan's conservative worldview with the country's economic development is a dilemma for Japan, resulting in economic stagnation and a shrinking labour force population. This difficulty is caused by Japan's patriarchal worldview, which views women after marriage as undeserving of employment and how they must take care of the family no matter what. As a result, Japanese women opt not to marry or even refuse to have children after marriage to further their professions because having children or getting married is considered a death sentence. In order to enable women to advance their professions, have families, and have children, Abe developed the Womenomics initiative during his time as prime minister.

Nevertheless, with the Japanese patriarchal mindset, they still think less of a woman based on their gender, not their capability in the workforce. Therefore, this initiative did not significantly impact encouraging women to work. According to Kingston (2013), Abe was harshly condemned for his choice, knowing that women are disenfranchised and earn less than males. However, Abe's epiphany came to an end without any action. Although Abe vowed to provide childcare for those women and mothers, their pay was significantly lower

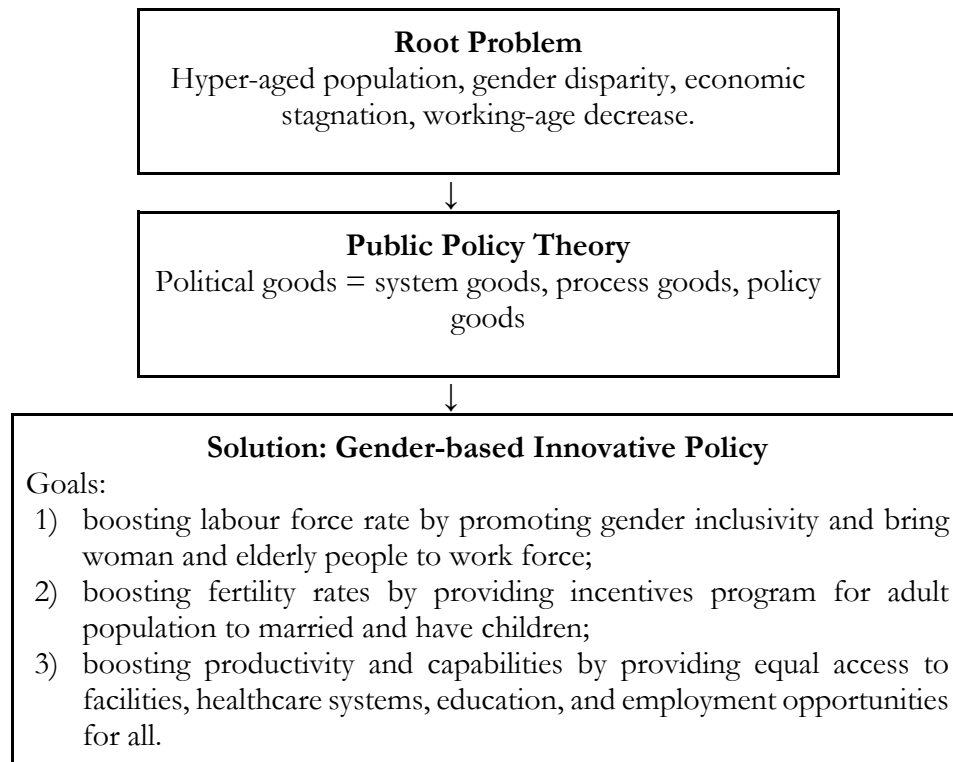
than that of males, leaving them unable to afford it. Finally, women are again forced to choose between their careers and their families.

Researchers utilised the Japanese Government's Japan Revitalization Strategy as the second study in this research. This Japanese Government plan discusses how Womenomics, a program begun by Abe during his term, is one of the growth strategies the Japanese Government employs to alleviate the impact of the country's hyper-aged population. Running the Womenomics program can help Japan escape the economic stagnation that has plagued them. This demonstrates how women can contribute to economic progress and play an essential role in society, particularly in the economic sector.

As the writing of this article will focus on the discussion of innovative public policy in Japan, the theory that should be used is public policy theory. In the book entitled "Comparative Politics Today", Powell, Dalton, and Strøm describe public policy as the entirety of authoritative public decisions made by the government, including the policy output of the political system. Policies are issued for a purpose that is generally intended to promote the end results which are referred as policy outcomes. In the nature of a democratic society, politicians usually have the drive to pursue political goals that seek to meet the values and aspirations of its citizens, this is known as "political goods".

Furthermore, this book also explained that there are three aspects that shape the political culture of a country which also utilises different orientations towards politics or political goods. The three aspects are system goods, process goods, and policy goods. System goods is the view of people towards the values and organisations that make up the political system of a country. At this level, the desired goal is the maintenance of a stable political system that can adapt to challenges and changes, including in terms of policies. Furthermore, process goods are citizen's expectations of political rules, decision-making methods, as well as the relationship of citizens with the government as a whole (inputs and outputs). The ideally achieved goals at the process level are citizen input (aspiration) to the government that is running well, there is compliance and support from citizens to the law and government, and there is also procedural justice in the political process or equality before the law. Finally, policy goods are the expectations of public policy towards government, such as welfare, security, fairness, and liberty (Powell, Dalton, and Strøm, 2015: 146-148).

Hence, in analysing Womenomics policy in Japan, this article identifies the policy based on the three aspects above, i.e. how the level of public policy at the system, process, and policy level can encourage the transformation of political culture that moves from a viscous patriarchal system toward a gender inclusive system. Furthermore, this article also analyses how hyper-aged population pressures, economic downturns, and international image factors can encourage the Japanese government to eliminate gender-biased policies which make women's roles segregated in social, political, and economic aspects for decades. Consequently, in the 21st century, the traditional role of "good wife and wise mother" or "*ryosai kenbo*" is slowly blurring and now Japanese women are managing to gain equal access in the labour force following the revision of the Equal Employment Opportunity Law in June 2006. If identified based on the indicators of goals, goods, outputs and outcomes, an analytical framework can be formulated as follows.



This article used a descriptive qualitative method. According to Lexy. J. Moleong, qualitative research is a form of research method that uses descriptive data implemented through written and unwritten words obtained through observed and researched social phenomena. As support for this work, the data gathered in this study were obtained through a literature study of journals and books relevant to the topic of innovative public policy “Womenomics” in conjunction with the Japan Revitalization Strategy to mitigate hyper-aged population and economic stagnation impact.

RESULT AND DISCUSSION

A. Mitigating Economic Stagnation with Gender Inclusivity as a Growth Strategy in Japan

Crucial problems in the post-war period overshadowed Japan. The Sakura Country was initially at its golden peak and known as the market leader from 1960 until the 1980s. It is now experiencing the phenomenon of a "loss-decade," which is when a hyper-aged population characterises a depopulation. The increasing elderly population and decreasing birth rates which the growth of productive age has not accompanied, are the two things causing this phenomenon. Japan was at its peak population in 2010, with 128.06 million citizens. However, Japan's population is projected to decline to 86.74 million by 2060, decreasing by about 41.32 million or 33.3% over 50 years (2010-2060).

Declining birth rates also support this hyper-aged population condition due to the low desire of young people to build a family and have children and the high suicide rate. The table below also shows that the projected birth rate continues to decline and will only reach 480,000, inversely proportional to the projected mortality rate of up to 1.54 million by 2060. This declining birth rate is due to social factors such as household pressures, patriarchy, career or job demands, and rising living costs.

Table 1. Japan's Population Age Structure (1960-2060)

	1960	1985	2010	2035	2060
A. Population in millions (index, 2010=100)	93.42 (73.0)	121.05 (94.5)	128.06 (100)	112.12 (87.6)	86.74 (67.7)
B. Children, 0–14	28.07 (166.7)	26.03 (154.6)	16.84 (100)	11.29 (67.0)	7.91 (47.0)
C. Working, 15–64	60.00 (73.4)	82.51 (101.0)	81.73 (100)	63.43 (77.6)	44.18 (54.1)
D. Elderly, 65 and over	5.35 (18.1)	12.47 (42.3)	29.48 (100)	37.41 (126.9)	34.64 (117.5)
(75 and over)	1.63 (11.5)	4.71 (33.2)	14.19 (100)	22.78 (160.5)	23.36 (164.6)
Proportion of elderly in pop. (D/A)	5.7%	10.3%	23%	33.4%	39.9%
Old-age dependency ratio (D/C)	8.9% (1 supported by 11)	15.1% (1 supported by 7)	36.1% (1 supported by 2.8)	59.0% (1 supported by 1.7)	78.4% (1 supported by 1.3)
Births in millions	1.61 (149.9)	1.43 (133.6)	1.07 (100)	0.71 (66.5)	0.48 (45.0)
Deaths in millions	0.71 (59.0)	0.75 (62.8)	1.20 (100)	1.66 (138.3)	1.54 (128.3)

Note. Adapted from *Population Census of Japan* (Statistics Bureau Ministry of Internal Affairs and Communications, n.d.); *Population Projections for Japan* (National Institute of Population and Social Security Research, 2012); *Defusing Japan's Demographic Time Bomb* (Nippon.com, 2012).

Japan, long known as a leader in the semiconductor, technology, automotive, and electronic products industries, is now facing acute social problems due to the need for more productive human resources. The population of productive age as a support for the country's foreign exchange (15-64 years) in the decade of 1960-19 80s has now essentially entered the elderly age. Instead, the state must spend more to support social security once they retire, starting from the pension fund, health insurance, and other living expenses. In the 1960s, Japan's old-age dependency ratio was only 8.9%, of which 11 productive people could support one older person. This figure then dropped to 36.1% in the 2010s, and only 2.8 productive residents can support one older person. The proportion of the non-productive age population (65 years and over) is projected to reach 33.4% in 2030 and 39.9% in 2060. This hyper-aged population condition has influenced Japan's growth stagnation over the last two decades. Even at its worst, Japan will not only lose its population but will also undergo massive changes in the structure of its society in the following decades.

Changes in the structure of society caused by the hyper-aged population pose a serious threat to Japan, which matters in conjunction with the social security system, which relies heavily on the economic output and the allocation of resources from the productive age population to support those who are not working. This burden is tangible; even in the composition of fiscal budget expenditures, Japan tends to pay more attention to the social security sector. In 2021, Japan budgeted up to 35.8 trillion Yen (33.6%) for social security and 23.7 trillion Yen for sovereign debt alone (22.3%) (Statistics Bureau, 2021: pp.36-37).

Even so, the budget for education and research is only 5.3 trillion Yen (5.1%), even though education and research are essential to boosting the development of the technology, industrial sector, and labor force quality. Not stopping there, the multiplier effect of demographic changing conditions also impacted the decline in economic growth during the recession and economic crisis in the 1990s until the Covid-19 pandemic in 2020. As a result, Japan's debt to GDP, which in 1991 only reached 38.9%, massively jumped to 216.3% in 2020 (World Bank, n.d.).

It is undeniable that human resources are a fundamental aspect of a nation-state. This could be seen from the changes in demographic conditions that have become a catalyst for the decline in economic growth and harm to Japan's social and political security sectors. From a political aspect, if the depopulation trend continues to increase in the future, this has the potential to reduce Japan's "national power" in the international eyes because the population is one of the country's power aspects in addition to economic power.

From the economic side, the three fundamental aspects of economic growth are the accumulation of capital, resources, and technology (Nippon.com, 2012). In terms of capital accumulation, a more significant proportion of expenditures compared to state revenues exacerbated by the high debt ratio and sluggish investment/assets also impact the inaction of Japan's economic recovery. Also, this happened due to the continued reduction of the working-age population in Japan, which has an impact on decreasing the level of capital deposits or savings. Japan will also find it challenging to attract investors because the target market needs to be more impressive as a consequence of the dwindling human resources that can produce and buy new products, technologies, and facilities. Even worse, this could lead to deindustrialization and diminishing access to employment in Japan. Therefore nowadays, many companies tend to move their manufactures to developed and underdeveloped countries compared to operating in developed countries because of worker's wages and cheaper resources factors. On the other hand, the declining population in Japan will have a long-term effect on reducing the labour force participation rate in the country.

In addition, the socioeconomic impact of depopulation itself is a complex and multi-layered problem. Of course, more than one fiscal or monetary policy is needed to solve this problem. There are at least two crucial things to work towards mitigating the negative economic impacts of the hyper-aged population in Japan today, thus are: 1) increasing the number of the labour force; and 2) increasing productivity by expanding access to inclusive education, facilities, and resources.

The main concern in pursuing the first goal is what efforts must be conducted to encourage women and older people in Japan to enter the labour force. Japan has a long history of gender inequality that causes discrimination against women in social, economic, and political aspects. In the private and public spheres, marginalisation of Japanese women happens often, so they need the opportunity and the space to maximise their potential, whether in education, career, or household. Women's contribution is undoubtedly precious for the development and future of a nation-state.

When we look back to history, patriarchal conditions became increasingly entrenched when the momentum of the "economic miracle" was marked by the rapid economic development in Japan in the 1960-1970s. This momentum has implications for social transformation, namely the conception of "husband as breadwinner" and "wife as housekeeper" as a collective understanding of Japanese society. In addition, Japan also has a bad reputation in the international eyes related to the fulfilment of women's rights, mainly when women were used as political tools during the occupation and war period and the "comfort women" became a vicious fact (Arifin, 2021: pp.2-4). Thus, to improve Japan's image in the international eye and address the hyper-aged population problem,

transformative policies promoting gender equity in Japan are needed. Besides, a collective understanding is also needed. Indeed, women's empowerment is indispensable to awakening Japan from prolonged economic stagnation.

After escaping from a firmly rooted patriarchal system, "Abenomics" became one of the growth strategies initiated in 2013 by Shinzo Abe, the former Prime Minister of Japan. *Abenomics* is an economic policy with a "three arrows or prongs of economic revival" strategy to liberate Japan from postwar economic stagnation. One of the programs contained in the "Japan Revitalization Strategy" is then known as "Womenomics," which was made to encourage and promote women in the labour force, one of the great potentials of Japan that have not been maximised before. This policy is implemented by providing equal opportunities for women in job recruitment and filling strategic or high positions in companies or institutions. The policy is part of the "Growth Strategy in Three Action Plan" to strengthen the Japan Revitalization Strategy. This policy also provides incentives for women when they have children to support childcare and household roles. This is also expected to increase the birth rate in Japan to break the hyper-aged population chain.

B. Womenomics: New Hope for Japan's Social-economic Reform

Many social phenomena are increasingly developing in times that are increasingly experiencing global changes. One of the problems that are often encountered is the issue of gender equality which is still being discussed today—reflecting on the transition from the 20th to the 21st century, many transformations in technology, education, the economy, and workers' issues. All forms of development that occur are, of course, caused by various social phenomena. Especially in Japan because developed countries have experienced many changes in their social and cultural life. As in Japanese work culture in the industrial and other sectors. Japan's success as an industrialising country that resulted in the country's economy being developed also has a long history that occurred before. This long history has not spared Japan's socio-cultural problems in the economic sector, especially labour issues. Gender disparities can be seen in Japanese work culture, where male workers dominate more than female workers, and women participate in other public activities.

The Second World War impacted Japan, especially the Japanese economic sector, which ultimately led to Japan's demographic problems, in which there was an increase and decrease in birth rates in Japan. The aftermath of the war also impacted the lifestyle of Japanese people with a hard-working ethic. The impact has also triggered workers, not only men but women in Japan, to be more aggressive in looking for work so that they do not have time to take care of other interests, such as getting married and having children. Those women with a mindset that equalises their position with males create effects that trigger workers, as evidenced by the rise of women in Japan's labour sector. In fact, in its development from time to time, especially in the modern era, women in Japan are very active in pursuing education up to the university to target various sectors of well-known companies in Japan. Helping women in the world of work cannot be separated from the role of women's emancipation and the influence of feminist ideas.

The Japanese government is famous for elevating women's status, namely Shinzo Abe. Developments that occurred in the 20th century caused the movement of workers in Japan to experience developments in the military field and expansion, resulting in rapid industrialization. The developments in industrialization resulted in a significant increase in the number of workers in Japan, especially women. In 1999, one of the Japanese figures named Matsui coined the term Womenomics. The term means uplifting and increasing the number of female workers in Japan. The emergence of the term Womenomics provided development during former Japanese prime minister Shinzo Abe's reign in helping Japan

improve its economy. In 2000 it was recorded that 40.7% of the total workers in Japan were women aged 15 to 65 years. The status of workers in Japan also varies, 56.9% are married women, and 33.1% are single (Saleha, 1976).

The Womenomics Policy in Japan centred on the economy and women to tackle existing difficulties, ranging from worker equality for women to Japan's demographic problems. In the 21st century, women started to occupy positions in tertiary industries, restaurants, finance, and insurance. According to the Bureau of Statistics, Management and Coordination Agency, Labor Force Survey in 2000, eight out of ten women in Japan were housewives who took part-time jobs. The effect of an increasing number of female employees in Japan has resulted in a fall in the number of birth rates in Japan. A decrease in the birth rate due to the Bankonka phenomenon, essentially delaying marriage. This effect developed into a condition that led to a demographic crisis.

Besides, there has been an increase in the education sector which is dominated by women and opens up more job opportunities as a result. This increase is reflected in the number of women's educational interests equal to men's due to the phenomenon that occurred in 2015. Former Japanese Prime Minister Shinzo Abe published the form of a policy constructed in 1999 and then enacted in 2015, namely "Abenomics". He proposed action in several three focus areas, namely: 1) monetary policy; 2) fiscal policy; and 3) structural reform policy (Sari & Henriette, 2020).

Research by Kathy Matsui discussing Womenomics and eventually being adopted by the Japanese government also has a connection with the Act on Promotion of Women's Participation and Advancement in the Workplace policy in 2016. The term is an economic strategy called Abenomics, which discusses three focus areas related to Monetary Policy, Fiscal Policy, and Structural Reform Policy. The strategic focus of structural reform policy includes the "Womenomics Policy". Three key performance indicators are: 1) an increase in women's representation in leadership roles by 30% in 2020; 2) an increasing proportion of women working in the 25–44 age range from 68% in 2012 to 73% by 2020; and 3) an increasing proportion of women returning to work—from 38% in 2010 to 55% by 2020. These goals were set for successfully implementing the Womenomics Policy.

The existence of Womenomics policies cannot be separated from input by Japanese society to tackle the gender inequality that occurs for so long. In its case, Japan prefers the role of men in the employment sector, both industrial and other jobs. This resulted in the community, especially women, also taking actions that gave aspiration to the Japanese government system. At first, the Womenomics policy sparked from the Act on Promotion of Women's Participation and Advancement in the Workplace policy in 2016 with an economic strategy called Abenomics as a pillar of Shinzo Abe.

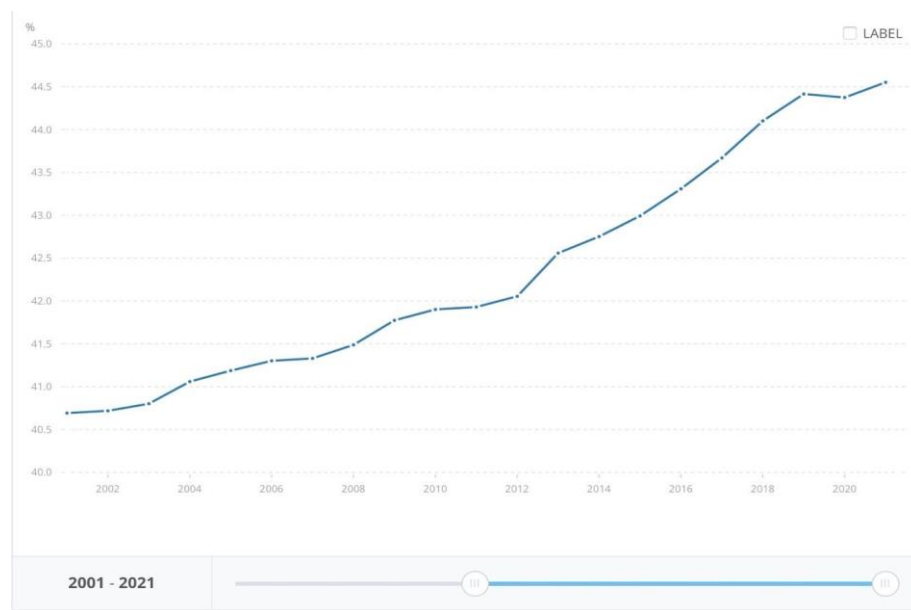
In 2020 it can be seen that the number of female permanent workers in Japan has increased, but not by a significant amount. According to the Japanese Prime Minister's website published in 2014, there are three arrows in the Abenomics policy, namely the first to restore opinions (country and opinion levels), the second to develop creative ideas so that they continue to develop and the last to encourage new industries for the regional realm. In the discussion of the three abenomic policy arrows, it is more directed towards revitalising the Japanese economy. In the discussion of the second point, there is discussion regarding gender equality to obtain the results of increasing the participation and welfare of Japanese women. The Abenomic policy, which in turn is often known as the Womenomics policy which was published and implemented from 2013. In providing support to women, the Japanese government works closely with the Ministry of Economy, Trade and Industry; the Ministry of Health, Labor and Social Affairs and the Gender Gap Bureau. The involvement of various bureaus that are invited to work together has a function in promoting women in

various types of employment as well as overcoming cases of gender inequality and proposing policies.

In pursuing the success of Womenomics policies, there are two efforts to increase women's participation and welfare. The first target is to provide access to women who already have married status and have children to obtain a conducive work environment. There are also new steps that will be implemented in the form of setting up after-school daycare, increasing the number of teaching staff for school children and providing additional services for child care services. The second target is to provide access for women to gain advancement in careers at work. This second point also has the implementation of new steps that will be implemented in the form of promoting positions in the leadership sector and reforming the tax system and social security for both husband and wife.

As a result of the Womenomics Policy implementation, there has been an increase in women worker's rate in Japan. This number has grown stable, especially from 2001 to 2021. Based on the following World Bank statistical data below, it can be seen that the percentage of female workers in 2001-2002 was already 40.7% and then it jumped to 44,6% in 2021. From this statistical data, female workers in Japan have consistently increased from year to year.

Figure 1. Data Statistic Labour Force Females in Japan



Source: World Bank (n.d.)

Even though the absorption of female workers in Japan tends to increase, the efforts made by former Japanese Prime Minister Shinzo Abe indeed continue to experience challenges in the culture of workers in Japan, especially for women. Although a policy has been issued with the ideas conveyed, more women and men workers still need to be. This policy results in inequalities in it that are visible in the economic sector and employment. According to the OECD (Organization for Economic Co-Operation and Development) report, this inequality has resulted in a wage gap for women and men with a percentage of 24.5% as of 2018.

The employment system influences women's employment position in Japan's world of work. Many women work in non-regular employment systems with low wages, there are deadlines, they have much more specific job obligations, and there are very few women workers who occupy managerial positions (Annisa Yuliana Sari & Henriette, 2020). The Human Resource Management labour market, involving gender differences, also affects the wage gap for women (Hara, 2016).

CONCLUSION

Based on the description in the discussion above, the Womenomics policy is an essential pillar in Japan. Aside from that, it also works as a growth strategy that is ideal to be applied at the public policy level to mitigate the impact of the hyper-aged population and economic stagnation in Japan. From the three goals highlighted in the gender-based innovative policy solution in the framework, the progress is already underway, but it needs to be re-evaluated, including:

1. Boosting labour force rate by promoting gender inclusivity and bringing women and older people to the workforce;
2. boosting fertility rates by providing incentives program for the adult population to marry and have children;
3. boosting productivity and capabilities by providing equal access to facilities, healthcare systems, education, and employment opportunities for all

First, in terms of system goods, the Japanese government, pioneered by former Prime Minister Shinzo Abe, transformed a notoriously conservative political and governmental system into a more gender-inclusive system by releasing the "Japanese Revitalization Strategy" in 2013. This is also driven by adopting international norms that demand equality for all, especially human rights and gender equality issues, to improve Japan's image internationally. At the same time, encourage women to enter the labour force to mitigate the scarcity of productive age caused by the hyper-aged population. This can be seen from the increasing participation rate of Japanese women in the labour force from year to year, and this became a new hope for Japan to get out of economic stagnation.

Second, from the process goods level, there is a long process and history that comes from women's movements and glass-ceiling phenomena in Japan that demand equality and rights of Japanese women in social, economic, political, and educational aspects. So far, Japanese women have been confined by stigma and patriarchal conditions that limit their potential. Hence, Womenomics and other gender-based policies represent the process of public policy inputs and outputs between the government and society that articulates its interests.

Third, from the policy goods sphere, Womenomics policy theoretically pays attention to welfare, security, fairness, and liberty. However, in terms of implementation, many problems must be resolved, including the wage gap issue, social stigma, the double burden of being a homemaker, and other demands attached to Japanese women. Furthermore, supporting policies are needed to ensure that women have an equal access to facilities, health, education and training, and equal career path opportunities.

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